



POLITICS **IN** **NIGERIA**

OLUGBODI EMMANUEL

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Olugbodi Emmanuel

DEDICATION

To all citizens of Nigeria committed to national progress.

PREFACE

Politics in Nigeria! There is no way we can discuss Nigerian politics without mentioning the keyword “Democracy.”

The word democracy comes from the Greek words ‘demos’, meaning people, and ‘kratos’, meaning power. Hence, democracy can be understood as the “power of the people,” a way of governing that depends on the will of the people.

According to Schumpeter (1947), democracy means that the people can accept or reject those who are to govern them. By this, democracy implies conducting elections and choosing leaders who will represent the majority.

Democracy is government by the people. It is a form of government in which supreme power is vested in the people and exercised directly by them or through their elected agents under a free electoral system.

Before democracy in Nigeria, the system of governance was based on military rule. During those periods, absolute power rested solely with the government. The opinion of the people could not dictate government decisions because there was no opportunity to vote or be voted for, and there was no concept of political parties.

However, democracy makes it possible for citizens to be actively involved in choosing their leaders. Hence, people participate in the process of forming a government. They have free will and the right to vote for parties and leaders of their choice. And this right is universal and is not restricted by wealth, social class, or ethnicity.

In a democratic system, different parties present a manifesto or a set of ideas about how a country should be governed. Thus, a democratic government is formed when a majority of people support a particular party as the ruling party.

Undoubtedly, the democratic system of government is a demonstration of political activity. Thus, politics can be described as the activities involved in the making of government or the functioning of government.

Politics is a broad institution comprising different categories of people with varying ideologies. Politics may be bound by certain rules and regulations, yet its deeper activities require intelligence and participation.

So, what can we say about political activity in Nigeria? Everything about these activities (both cunning and unwise) is what will be discussed in this book.

Therefore, this book will focus on four major topics:

- ❖ Political parties
- ❖ Elections
- ❖ Appointments
- ❖ Governance

APPOINTMENT

After voting concludes and results are collated, the various candidates who won the election are announced, signalling that they will soon officially assume their political positions.

Using the state governor level as an example, once in office, the governor will need to appoint Commissioners, Special Advisers, Managing Directors, and other officials who will work together to achieve effective governance.

What is an appointment?

An appointment is the act of assigning a job or position to someone; it is the designation of a person to hold an office or discharge a trust.

Political appointments are particularly important because elected officials, especially those in high positions such as the President or a state Governor, require individuals to work with their administration to ensure efficient and effective governance. These individuals, often called political appointees, take charge of government agencies and parastatals and help turn policies into action.

Political appointees carry significant responsibilities. They support the administration by implementing decisions, formulating policies, promoting government programmes, and ensuring that civil servants carry out these policies effectively. In short, they are the energy behind governance, translating political promises into tangible outcomes.

However, when appointments are not based on merit, problems arise. In Nigeria, many appointments are influenced by politics rather than competency. When positions are awarded on a partisan basis to individuals who have supported the governing party, this practice is known as political patronage.

What is political patronage?

Political patronage is the appointment or hiring of a person to a government post based on partisan loyalty. Elected officials at national, state, and local levels often use such appointments to reward individuals who helped them win or maintain office.

Political patronage can also involve dispensing state resources as rewards for political or electoral support. These resources may include lucrative public sector contracts or prestigious roles within the civil service.

An act of political patronage typically involves two parties: a patron, who uses their influence to assist, protect, or benefit someone else, and a client, who receives benefits from the patron in exchange for

political allegiance or other services. Political patronage is often accompanied by other corrupt practices, such as nepotism (favoritism toward family members), cronyism (favoritism toward friends), or trading influence.

In Nigeria, this practice has been a major setback to national development, as many political appointments are not based on merit. Political patronage, nepotism, and favouritism have become common features of the system.

Poor structural organisation has significantly contributed to the problem of political patronage. In some cases, even when the government succeeds in appointing competent administrative leaders, the existing structure makes it difficult for such appointees to perform their duties effectively.

Poor structural organisation manifests in two main ways. Either the structure enables the government to comfortably make wrong appointments, or the structural arrangements are designed in such a way that they influence appointees, whether competent or not, to become ineffective in their respective roles.

Unfortunately, the structure of appointments in Nigeria does not only permit wrong appointments but also further aggravates their effects on the nation.

One major consequence of wrong appointments is bad governance, which often results in poor administrative control, flawed

decision-making, embezzlement, and other related issues. There are instances where elected political officeholders are genuinely willing to perform their duties diligently and effectively. However, when those responsible for implementing policies are incompetent, the entire system of governance tends to fail. Thus, any leader who genuinely desires effective governance in a state or country will strive to minimise these practices to the lowest possible level.

Another consequence of wrong appointments is the absence of proper inspection, evaluation, criticism, interrogation, and punishment. Elected officeholders often use appointments as a means of consolidating their power by empowering individuals who pose no threat to their administration. As a result, agencies responsible for investigating offenders ignore misconduct, those that should criticize the governments are dining with them, and institutions meant to deliver justice sometimes ignore unlawful activities.

This situation must be addressed. Government exists to ensure good governance, and appointing the right individuals to public office is a crucial step towards achieving this goal.

The relevant question, therefore, is what necessary steps should be taken in selecting political appointees. One important consideration is that appointments should be based on administrative qualifications and competence. There should be no room for favouritism at any level,

particularly where individuals lack the required qualifications. Ethical standards alone should not be the sole basis for appointments.

The structure guiding political appointments should make it difficult to select unqualified candidates. This can be achieved through the enactment and enforcement of appropriate laws that ensure proper screening of appointees. With effective screening processes, the rate of wrong appointments can be significantly reduced, even if it may not be completely eliminated.

In addition, political appointees should be closely monitored and scrutinised in the course of their service. When proper oversight is lacking, many appointees become involved in unlawful activities. Thus, there must be a commitment to investigating political appointees who engage in such misconduct. Periodic reporting and auditing should be mandatory, as there are cases where reports spanning several years remain unaudited. These lapses must be minimised if effective governance is to be achieved.

Punishment has always been, and will continue to be, a vital tool for curbing corruption among appointed officeholders. In some cases, individuals are appointed based on competence and administrative ability, yet succumb to corruption due to peer pressure. When others engage in unlawful practices without consequences, even well-intentioned officials may be tempted to follow the same path.

Therefore, appropriate punishment must be enforced not only to penalise offenders but also to deter others from engaging in similar unlawful acts